CONCEPT PAPER

DIGITAL TECHWISE EMPOWERMENT INITIATIVE

- **Project Mission**

"To empower underserved youth and women in Kenya by enhancing digital hygiene, expanding access to digital tools, and fostering opportunities for education, entrepreneurship, and financial inclusion through and working with partners to create inclusive digital opportunities."

- **Goal**

  To advance digital inclusion by equipping underserved youth and women in rural Kenya with digital skills, tools, and resources that enhance their access to education, employment, and economic opportunities.

- **Mission**

Building inclusive digital communities in Kenya by promoting digital hygiene, expanding access, digital skilling and, partnering for sustainable opportunity

4. Objectives

- Train at least 1,000 youth and women in digital skills and digital hygiene during the first year.
- Distribute 2,500 refurbished smartphones to beneficiaries in targeted counties by year one.
- Establish and support 12 community digital access centers with digital hygiene and literacy resources.
- Increase access to affordable internet for vulnerable communities through partnerships with telcos and community hubs.
- Provide entrepreneurship and digital finance mentorship to small businesses and youth-led startups.
- Advocate for digital inclusion policies by engaging government agencies, NGOs, and private sector stakeholders.

5.Target Beneficiaries

- Primary: Youth (15–35 years), People With Disabilities, and women in rural and peri-urban Arid and Semi-Arid Lands (ASALs),
- Initial focus counties: Laikipia, Tharaka Nithi, Kajiado, Narok, Isiolo, and Makueni, Kitui

Key Activities

- Community mobilization and beneficiary registration.
- Digital literacy and digital hygiene workshops.

- Device collection, refurbishment, and equitable distribution.
- Supporting community digital hubs with training and awareness materials.
- Ongoing mentorship for digital entrepreneurship and financial inclusion.
- Continuous monitoring, evaluation, and reporting.
- Fundraising in support of key programmes and activities.

6.Expected Results / Outcomes

- At least 1,000 youth and women acquire practical digital skills.
- 2,500 beneficiaries gain access to refurbished smartphones and internet-enabled tools.
- Improved access to online education, e-services, and employment opportunities in targeted counties.
- Greater community awareness of digital hygiene, safety, and responsible technology use.
- Strengthened community-based support systems for sustaining digital inclusion.

7. Background and Justification

Kenya’s digital transformation has been unevenly distributed, with urban counties such as Nairobi, Kiambu, Nyeri, and Mombasa leading in internet adoption and access to digital tools, while remote and marginalized regions lag significantly behind. This disparity is especially pronounced in Northern Kenya, where counties such as Turkana, Mandera, Marsabit, Wajir, Garissa, Samburu, and Tana River face some of the lowest levels of connectivity, device ownership, and digital literacy nationwide.

According to the **2023/24 Kenya Housing Survey** by the Communications Authority (CA) and the Kenya National Bureau of Statistics (KNBS), internet usage nationally averages 35.0%. However, in Northern counties the figures are drastically lower Turkana (12.7%), Marsabit (16.3%), Garissa (16.5%), Tana River (15.5%), and West Pokot (9.1%). By comparison, Nairobi records 64.7% and Kiambu 54.0%. Computer ownership and usage show a similar trend: while 27.8% of Nairobi residents report using computers, usage drops to just 3.5% in Mandera, 3.5% in Marsabit, 3.7% in Tana River, and 2.0% in Wajir.

Mobile phone ownership, although more widespread nationally, is also significantly lower in Northern Kenya. Counties such as West Pokot (29%), Turkana (29.4%), Marsabit (34.8%), Tana River (35.5%), and Samburu (36.8%) fall far below the national average, compared to Nairobi (67.7%) or Kirinyaga (65.0%). These figures highlight the infrastructural and affordability barriers that prevent many households in marginalized counties from participating in Kenya’s digital economy.

The digital exclusion in Northern Kenya disproportionately affects vulnerable groups youth, women, persons with disabilities, and the elderly. Nationally, men are more likely than women to use the internet (37.8% vs. 32.2%), but in rural and marginalized counties this gender gap is wider due to social norms, literacy barriers, and affordability challenges. These inequalities exacerbate already high unemployment rates. While Kenya's youth unemployment averages about 11.9% nationally, rates in Northern counties are far higher Garissa (~62%), Turkana (~56%), Mandera (~52%), and Wajir (~51%). In contrast, counties such as Nyeri and Embu record some of the lowest youth unemployment rates (~13%).

These disparities demonstrate an urgent need for targeted digital empowerment interventions in Northern Kenya. Without deliberate investment, marginalized counties will continue to fall behind, widening national inequalities and constraining Kenya's ability to achieve inclusive digital transformation as outlined in the **National Digital Economy Blueprint**, **Vision 2030**, and the **Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs 4, 8, 9, and 10)**.

This initiative is designed to bridge the digital divide in these underserved regions by:

- Expanding affordable access to internet-enabled devices and connectivity.
- Providing foundational and advanced digital skills training tailored to youth, women, and small businesses.
- Delivering mentorship, entrepreneurship support, and access to technology hubs in target counties.
- Building inclusive community support systems to sustain digital empowerment.

By focusing on the most excluded counties Laikipia,Kajiado,Turkana, Mandera, Marsabit, Garissa, Wajir, Samburu, and Tana River the program directly addresses regional inequalities, promotes youth employment, empowers women, and enhances socio-economic resilience. Investing in digital inclusion in Northern Kenya will not only transform lives locally but also strengthen Kenya's overall competitiveness and ability to thrive in a rapidly digitalizing global economy.

- **Internet usage** nationally stands at **35.0%**, but starkly different in urban settings (56.5%) versus rural (25.0%)
- **Computer usage** among individuals aged 3 years and above is just **11.6%**, with only about **20%** in urban areas and around **7%** in rural areas
- **Household access to computers** is also extremely low: nationally about **10.7%** of households own a computer, while some counties (e.g. Mandera, Marsabit) report computer ownership as low as **1.1%**

These infrastructure and access gaps are compounded by mobile and gender divides: while **93.8% of households** own a mobile phone, internet adoption and daily usage remain much lower in rural areas, and female users trail male users by a few percentage points in both internet access and digital literacy

The economic impact of these disparities is severe and youth are among the hardest hit. Key labor-market data include:

- Kenya's **youth unemployment** (ages 15-24) was **~12.2–11.9%** in 2023-2024, marginally declining from previous years.
- However, broader measures show higher unemployment or underemployment for ages **15-34**, with estimates as high as **67%**, especially when considering informal work, skills mismatch, and those neither in education nor training (NEET)
- Kenya's population is also very young approximately **80%** of the population is under the age of 35 amplifying the urgency for digital, education, and employment interventions
- Policymakers recognize the issue: The Urban-Rural Digital Divide report from CA and KNBS highlights strong correlation between internet/device access and income levels, education, electricity availability, and geography. Marginalized groups

women, older adults, persons with lower educational attainment are persistently disadvantaged

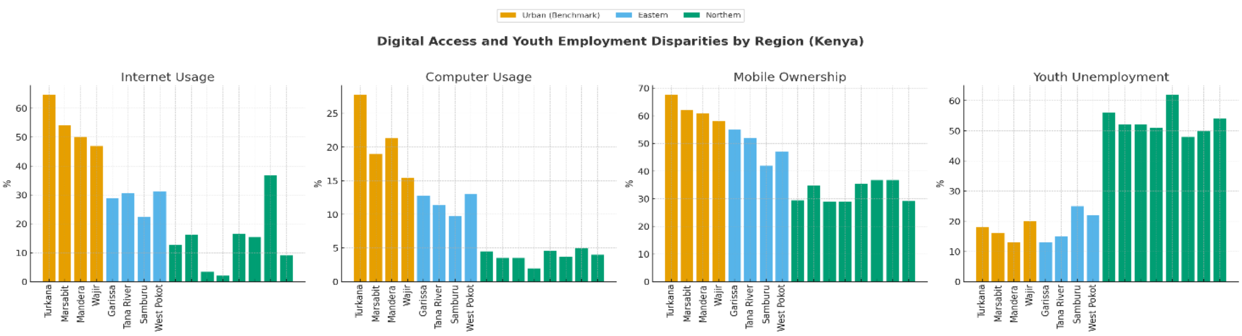
Why This Initiative is Essential Now

These combined data paint a picture of a digital divide that is not only severe but accelerating inequality across socio-economic, gender, and geographic lines. With youth unemployment remaining stubbornly high, especially outside the formal sector, hundreds of thousands of young people are entering the labor market with limited skills relevant to the digital economy. Without intervention, the gaps in access risk deepening, undermining inclusive growth and constraining Kenya's ability to meet national development goals and the UN SDGs.

This initiative—to provide affordable digital training, mentorship, technology resources, and community support—is therefore both critical and timely. It will help bridge the access and skills gaps, unlock education and employment opportunities for marginalized populations (especially youth, women, and rural residents), and thereby reinforce Kenya's competitiveness, innovation capacity, and social inclusion in the digital age.

Kenya County-Level Digital & Employment Statistics

County	Internet Usage (%)	Computer Usage (%)	Mobile Ownership (%)	Youth Unemployment (%)
Nairobi	64.7	27.8	67.7	18.0
Kiambu	54.0	19.0	62.1	16.0
Nyeri	50.1	21.3	61.0	13.0
Mombasa	46.9	15.4	58.0	20.0
Embu	28.9	12.8	55.0	13.0
Meru	30.5	11.4	52.0	15.0
Kitui	22.4	9.7	42.0	25.0
Machakos	31.2	13.0	47.0	22.0
Turkana	12.7	4.5	29.4	56.0
Marsabit	16.3	3.5	34.8	52.0
Mandera	3.5	3.5	29.0	52.0
Wajir	2.0	2.0	29.0	51.0
Garissa	16.5	4.6	35.5	62.0
Tana River	15.5	3.7	36.8	48.0
Samburu	36.8	5.0	36.8	50.0
West Pokot	9.1	4.0	29.1	54.0



Here’s a **single infographic-style summary chart** with all four indicators (internet usage, computer usage, mobile ownership, and youth unemployment) side by side.

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6. Implementation Timeline

Phase	Activity	Timeline
Phase 1	Planning and partnerships	Months 1–2
Phase 2	Device/material sourcing and training design	Months 3–4
Phase 3	Training delivery and device distribution	Months 5–10
Phase 4	Monitoring, evaluation, and reporting	Months 11–12

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9. Budget Estimate

Item	Estimated Cost (USD)
Device refurbishment and logistics	$25,000
Training sessions and materials	$15,000
Personnel and facilitators	$10,000
Monitoring and evaluation	$5,000
Miscellaneous/Administration	$5,000
Total	**$60,000**

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10. Sustainability Plan

- Train **local digital ambassadors** to continue peer-to-peer capacity building.
- Develop **community-based mobile apps and platforms** for ongoing learning and resource sharing.
- Partner with **county governments, telcos, and NGOs** to expand internet accessibility and co-fund digital centers.
- Establish a **digital entrepreneurship pipeline** linking trained youth and women with microfinance, incubators, and markets.
- Build in **cost-recovery mechanisms** (e.g., affordable subscription fees, service charges at hubs) to ensure long-term viability.

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